

"AND LET US CONSIDER HOW WE MAY SPUR ONE ANOTHER ON TOWARD LOVE AND GOOD DEEDS, NOT GIVING UP MEETING TOGETHER."—**HEBREWS 10:24–25**

GROUP LEADERS

Group Leader Handbook · Southeast Students

2026–2027

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For permissions contact: Justin Davis at jdavis@secc.org

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HELP ALONG THE WAY

WELCOME, NEW LEADER

LET'S GET TO WORK

We're so glad you're here. Stepping into student ministry matters now more than ever. This is not about showing up once a week—you're joining a movement of what God is doing to change lives for eternity.

143,556 students are without Christ in our region. They don't know Jesus—but change starts one student at a time—and God wants to use you.

Every game, every question, every text, every time you show up—it matters. Students need consistent voices who love them, listen, speak truth, and point them to Jesus. You may become one of the most spiritually influential people in their lives.

You're not just a volunteer; you're a shepherd—and you're not doing it alone. You're part of a team that will equip, support, and pray with you.

Will you lead with urgency, love, and courage this year? We believe God will use you in powerful ways.

GRATEFUL,
YOUR STUDENT MINISTRY TEAM

01

SECTION 01

THE MISSION

Why we exist—the one calling that gets everyone working toward the same goal.

THE MISSION

WHY WE EXIST

SOUTHEAST CHRISTIAN CHURCH · MISSION

Connecting people to Jesus and to one another.

That means every effort, every prayer at Southeast works to fulfill it—Student Ministry included. Our mission is biblically rooted in both:

THE GREAT COMMANDMENT

Matthew 22:37–39

"Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind. ... And a second is like it: love your neighbor as yourself."

THE GREAT COMMISSION

Matthew 28:19–20

"Go therefore and make disciples of all nations ... and behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age."

As a member of the Student Ministry team—no matter your role, from leading a group to welcoming people at the door—this is what you're signing up to do.

FOUR QUESTIONS

Connecting students to Jesus and one another starts with four questions for every leader:

01 **How am I connecting to Jesus?**

Your connection to Christ matters more than what you offer in service to Christ. God's Word and prayer are the fuel for an effective ministry.

02 **How am I connecting to one another?**

Being connected to Jesus isn't enough. Jesus modeled community through the Trinity, but also through the disciples he walked with. Remember, ministry is a team effort.

03 **How am I connecting people to Jesus?**

As we are transformed, our purpose shifts. Jesus understood His mission—to seek and save the lost. He left the mission in the disciples' hands. That mission is now yours to carry.

04 **How am I connecting people to one another?**

Neighborhoods, schools, workplaces and families need you to have vision for cultivating community. Belonging often opens the door of reception to Christ.

02

SECTION 02

YOUR GROUP

What a win looks like—and how to build a group where students belong.

COMMITMENTS & EXPECTATIONS

THE BASICS

01 **Co-leaders + Teams**

Every small group leader has at least one co-leader. You and your co-leader(s) sit on a larger team of other leaders from your grade and all leaders in your ministry (MSM or HSM).

02 **On Time + Prepared**

"*On time*" means 30 minutes before service. "*Prepared*" means 30 minutes spent reading the passage, writing questions, and praying for your group.

03 **Year Long Commitment**

August to July. Students thrive on consistency. Jesus raised the bar, not us. Your co-leader covers you for sickness or travel.

04 **Model The Way**

Students don't need perfection—they need people who follow Jesus with their whole life. You model the way at church, in your neighborhood, and on social media.

05 **Cultivate Community**

Be a cultivator of community on your team and in the group you lead. Be the teammate you wish you had.

3 WINS FOR STUDENT GROUPS

THREE WINS

"HIGH ACCOUNTABILITY, LOW CONTROL"

01 **Connect to Jesus**

Did your students open the Bible? It would be a mistake to gather with students and never open God's living and active Word. Make this the priority.

02 **Connect to one another**

Did your students connect? Watch for the one sitting off to the side on their phone, and help the group pull them back in. Students just want simple relational connection.

03 **One at a time**

One meal, one conversation, one need, one prayer. Keep a listening ear open—listen for ways you can follow up during the week.

SMALL GROUP LEADER EXPECTATIONS

WHAT WE ASK OF YOU

Five expectations, one for each of our mantras—the pictures from the life of Christ that shape how we lead.



BE THE BRANCH John 15:1–17

Have a rich personal walk with Jesus.

- Attend a weekend service.
- Be in a group of your own—Bible study, small group, etc.
- Have, or be seeking, a personal mentor.
- Be growing in your personal study and prayer disciplines.



CATCH THE WIND John 3:1–8

We raise the sails to catch the wind of the Holy Spirit. Where God is moving, we want to go.

- **Build the boat well.** Come prepared to minister to your students, having spent time in the week's curriculum.
- **Work with the wind.** Ask questions. Talk no more than 20% of group time.
- **Know your crew.** Know how to push each student, when to give them their moment, and when to redirect.



WRECK THE ROOF Luke 5:18–25

Heaven and hell are a reality. Lead like you believe it. We will do whatever it takes to bring one more student to Jesus.

- Create new ways to connect with your group—hang-outs, bringing things to group.
- Lead your group to invite friends. Plan how you will celebrate a new student, and create a group identity.
- Know where each student is spiritually. Anyone not baptized? Anyone struggling with faith?
- **Have a Timothy.** When asked, be able to say their name. Do for one what you wish you could do for everyone.



GRIP THE PLOW Luke 9:57–62

Jesus recruited people by telling them how hard it would be, not how great it would be.

- Serve with HSM or MSM every week, including the leader meeting.
- Have one touchpoint with a student outside of service each week—a text, a shared scripture, coffee, a game or recital.



EMPTY THE JAR Luke 7:36–50

Sacrificial ministry looks different for everyone. In student ministry it usually looks like time and margin.

- **Go to the big events:** Camp (HSC / MSC), Experience WKND (MSM overnight), Fall Retreat (HSM overnight).
- **Own a +1.** Step up and own one more responsibility: communion prep, set-up and tear-down, hosting, teaching, tech, contacting first-time guests.

03

SECTION 03

LEADING WELL

Preparing and facilitating—practical skills for every group night.

LEADING A GROUP

5 KEYS

01

Create an environment for discussion

Sit in a circle, on the same level. Everyone can see each other—and everyone feels free to share.

02

Turn statements into questions

Facilitate, don't teach. Use more question marks than periods, and skip yes-or-no questions.

03

Involve every student

Don't fill the silence with your own answer. Ask "What do you think?" and give it room—a little awkward silence never hurt anybody.

04

Don't read off the curriculum

Know the topic ahead of time and ask in your own words. The less you look down, the more it feels like a conversation.

05

Follow up during the week

Students need someone to walk with them, not talk at them. A relationship carried through the week can change a life.

WHEN A GROUP STALLS

GETTING UNSTUCK

01

Get easy wins

Blank stares usually mean the question was too hard. Ask simpler questions to build confidence, then work toward tougher ones.

02

Get fun

The first part of group is for fun, so students grow as a family. Use that time to earn the right to challenge them.

03

Get out

Experiences beyond Sunday—serving and showing up during the week—directly fuel your group time.

04

Get better questions

A great question yields as much as a great answer. Practice them before group; write a few of your own.

05

Get visual

A big sticky pad and a few markers pull everyone in. Drawing or writing answers makes the lesson stick.

04

SECTION 04

SHEPHERDING STUDENTS

Care and discipleship—meeting students where they are and helping them grow.

MEET STUDENTS WHERE THEY ARE

WHAT STUDENTS NEED

Every student has a need. Four chairs helps us pinpoint that need. As a leader, consider the following questions and see if God might reveal how you could meet the needs of the students around you.



CHAIR 1

THE LOST

"Come and See" John 1:35–39

NEEDS Christ-followers in their lives who are willing to enter into their world relationally.

QUESTIONS Who has God placed right around you? Are you entering into their world? Would people identify you as a "friend of sinners," as Jesus was? Are you willing to leave the comfort of your home or church to enter into the world of those without Christ?



CHAIR 2

THE BELIEVER

"Follow Me" John 1:43

NEEDS Christ-followers giving them personalized attention to the basics of the Christian life.

QUESTIONS Do they know God's story? Can they articulate their own story and how it fits into God's story? Do they know how to confess sin, claim God's forgiveness and walk in the power of the Holy Spirit? Are they learning to feed themselves?



CHAIR 3

THE WORKER

"Follow Me & I Will Make You Fishers of Men" Matthew 4:19

NEEDS Christ-followers calling them to action and to experience God using them.

QUESTIONS Are they faithful, available, teachable, enthusiastic about the things of God, and responsive to leadership? Are they ministering in the Spirit? Are they living out their spiritual gifts? Are they willingly bearing their cross daily?



CHAIR 4

DISCIPLE-MAKER

"Go and Bear Fruit" John 15:15–16

NEEDS To be a Christ-follower who is making disciple-making disciples.

QUESTIONS Have they successfully discipled someone into a disciple-maker? Are they secure in their walk with the Lord? Have they committed all of their life to fulfilling Jesus' Great Commission?

I WANT TO FOLLOW CHRIST

Five things a new believer needs to grow before becoming a worker—ask how Jesus shaped each in His disciples.

I — **Identity—who am I in Christ?**

Help new believers see their new identity—otherwise, letting the old self die feels like losing something precious instead of gaining it.

W — **Walk—how do I follow Christ?**

"Walk as Jesus walked" (1 John 2:6). Learn His character, His priorities, and His habits.

T — **Talk—what is the good news?**

Grow in gospel fluency and urgency—God's story, and how their story fits inside it.

F — **Feed—how do I feed myself?**

Make daily time with God a priority: prayer, worship, reading, journaling, or walking in His creation.

C — **Clean—what do I do when I sin?**

Walk students through daily repentance, confession, and a renewed commitment when sin creeps back in.

05

SECTION 05

DECISION GUIDE

Helping a student take their next step toward Jesus—and what to say in the moment.

BAPTISM



Purpose: to help a student reflect on their *decision* for Christ and the *commitment* of baptism.

1. STARTING QUESTIONS

- Tell me about your journey with Jesus so far.
- Why do you want to get baptized?
- Share with me your understanding of the gospel.
- Do you have any questions or things you're unsure about?

2. GOSPEL CONVERSATION *(SEE THE BRIDGE—NEXT PAGE)*

Genesis 1	God created us for relationship
Genesis 3	Sin breaks that relationship
Isaiah 59:2	Sin leads to separation from God
Romans 6:23	We deserve death, but God gifts us new life
Romans 5:8	Christ made a way back for us to God
Acts 2:38	Confession leads to forgiveness of sins

ROMANS 6:4

"We were therefore buried with him through baptism into death in order that, just as Christ was raised from the dead through the glory of the Father, we too may live a new life."

3. WHAT IS BAPTISM?

- Ask the student to read **Romans 6:1–7** aloud.
- Baptism is a symbol:

Dying to our **old life**	Rising to **new life** in Jesus
under the water	*coming up*

- Baptism doesn't save us. It is our response to what Jesus already did.

4. NOW WHAT?

- Read **2 Corinthians 5:17 to 6:2**.
- Today is the day of salvation! Will you go now and be Christ's ambassador? He wants to use you to reach others! Who will you tell?

THE BRIDGE

1 US + GOD

Genesis 1 describes the start of everything, including the start of humanity. God made us and began a relationship with us.

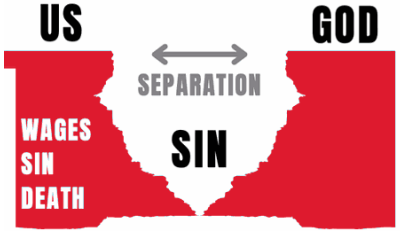
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Genesis 3 describes how our relationship with God was broken by humanity's disobedience.

We call this disobedience "sin." God can have nothing to do with sin. Read **Romans 3:23**.



3

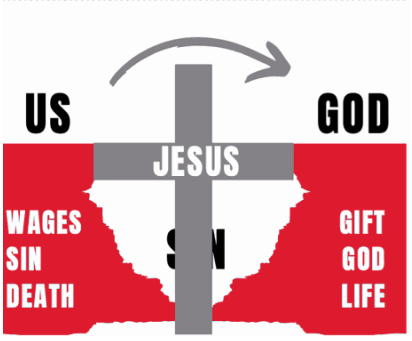


Romans 6:23 and **Isaiah 59:2** describe the problem sin creates and its consequences. Sin separates us from God and causes death. There is nothing we can do to return to God on our own.

4

Romans 5:8, **Romans 10:9–10** and **Acts 2:38** tell us about the solution. His name is Jesus.

Jesus died for everyone's sin, conquered death, and made a way for us to be with God again. When we trust in Jesus and choose to be baptized, we are saved!



06

SECTION 06

FURTHER RESOURCES

Help along the way—guides, notes, and where to go deeper.

CONVERSATIONS GUIDE



SE Students wants every leader to promote safety and awareness in tough conversations. Ministry is messy and these topics can feel intimidating—here are the **guidelines for how to best proceed**.

GREEN LIGHT

"Green means go."

You've got this. You have both the Sword and the Spirit.

- Family problems
- Relational problems
- Homesickness
- Heartfelt confessions
- Questions about dating & sex
- Church & theological questions

YELLOW LIGHT

"Proceed with caution."

Mention it to a staff member for coaching.

- Bullying
- Pornography
- Eating disorders
- Drugs or alcohol
- Anxiety or depression
- Engagement in sexual activity
- Gender & sexual identity questions

RED LIGHT

"Stop and get help."

Get a staff member and bring them into the conversation.

- Self-injury
- Hearing voices / hallucinations
- Sexual & physical abuse reported
- Suicidal / homicidal thoughts (threats to harm)

SPACE TO THINK

NOTES

SPACE TO THINK

NOTES


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CONNECTING PEOPLE TO JESUS & ONE ANOTHER